



SAIF KHAN
PERFORMS AT
THE IIFA AWARDS

lieved that Indian cinema had the potential to go global, which is why we wanted to showcase the event." And with stalwarts like Karan Johar on its advisory board, the audience has never seen any trouble over seating at any of their film awards functions. Thanks in part to the IIFA hoopla, Indian films are now released not just in Indian-dominated areas but even in mainline multiplexes in Europe, Thailand, the United Kingdom and Australia.

While the going has been fun, one incident that redefined their relationship and their business model was the Michael Jackson concert they organised in 1996. It taught them that if they had to be in the business of entertainment, they had no choice but to grow up. The memories still rankle as an agitated Timmins remembers the number of times he had to change his room at the Oberoi as every possible chief minister and police chief sought free tickets. Though a Rs 3.3-crore loss forced them into a spate of litigation and raids took the wind out of the company sails, the three became pragmatic about their financial dealings. Says Joseph: "We asked our suppliers to give us time and they agreed to waive 50 per cent of our dues and ex-

tended our repayment deadlines." This incident also paved their way into the events business. From weddings to product launches to film awards, Wizcraft can now successfully rustle up the perfect night out.

By 2000, the company had its finger in every entertainment pie—from Bollywood bashes to celebrity weddings. Apart from managing the opening and closing ceremonies of various sporting events around the world, Wizcraft is now handling other ceremonies of consequence, such as the Oman Tattoo—a military event held to celebrate the reign of the Sultan. The company's entertainment side is involved in conceptualising and execution of events, awards and production of television software such as *Sajid's Superstars* and *Nach Baliye 4*.

The company will conclude this year with the Live Earth Concert in Mumbai to raise funds for solar energy which will see performances by Bon Jovi and Amitabh Bachchan. Over the next few quarters, the trio wants to return to their first love, running a watering hole. The first, amongst what they hope will be more, is Howzzat, a beer café in Gurgaon. Indeed. Howzzat.

by Malini Bhupta

WIZCRAFT OWES
ITS SUCCESS TO
ITS THREE

PARTNERS
WHO HAVE
MAINTAINED
TRUST AND
REMAINED
FOCUSED IN
PURSUIT OF
THEIR GOALS